

IIT – English Language Course

Most vs. Mostly

(Brazil) Ariyañāṇa Bhikkhu

MOST VS. MOSTLY

- **most** = superlative / majority as a noun determiner
- **mostly** = adverb = "mainly / largely / for the most part"

If you confuse them, you're mixing **category vs. manner**.

"MOST" — as a determiner (quantity of a group)

Correct usage

- **Most people** prefer tea over coffee.
- **Most students** passed the exam.
- **Most of the water** was spilled.
- She spent **most of her time** reading.

What it does

It refers to a **majority of a noun group**.

- Key test

If you can replace it with:

– "the majority of ..."

then **most** is correct.

"MOST" — as a superlative

- This is the **most important rule**.
- He is the **most intelligent** student in class.
- That was the **most difficult** part.

Key test

If it's ranking one thing above all others → **most**

"MOSTLY" — adverb (degree / general condition)

Correct usage

- The room is **mostly clean**.
- I eat **mostly vegetarian food**.
- The audience was **mostly young people**.
- The work is **mostly done**.

What it does

It means:

- ”for the most part, but not entirely”

So it allows exceptions.

Direct contrast examples (high clarity)

Wrong vs. Correct

- ☐ Mostly students passed the exam.
 - ☐ Most students passed the exam.

Sharp distinction test

- Sentence A
 - **Most people agreed.**
 - * → talks about **how many people**
- Sentence B
 - ☐ Most the room is clean.
 - * ☐ The room is mostly clean.
 - People mostly agreed.
 - * → talks about **to what extent they agreed** (generally, but not all)

One-line mental model

- **most** = how many
- **mostly** = how much / to what extent